

Straight from the HEART

Men are moving out of the closet they had hidden in. A surprising 16 per cent admit they have had sex with men, mostly friends. Clearly, heterosexuality is not the only lifestyle choice.

| By Shohini Ghosh |

The “coming out” of sexuality is a significant development of post-liberalisation India. Provoking outrage in some and getting approval from others, sexuality today is a bitterly contested domain. One of the most visible examples of this struggle is currently on view at the Delhi High Court where the decriminalisation of homosexuality is being debated. Drafted by Lord Macaulay in 1860, Section 377 of the IPC criminalises “carnal intercourse against the order of nature with any man, woman or animal” with punishment by imprisonment extending up to 10 years. In 2001, Naz Foundation, an NGO working for HIV/AIDS, filed a petition in the Delhi High Court demanding the decriminalisation of consensual sex among adults. The petition is supported by Voices Against 377 (a coalition of human rights groups and individuals), the National AIDS Control Organisation (NACO) and the Health Ministry. The petition is being opposed by the Home Ministry (thereby placing the Government in a peculiar paradox), an NGO called JACK (which believes that the AIDS threat is a hoax) and V.P. Singhal (brother of Ashok Singhal of the VHP) who believes that criminalising homosexuality serves to



SPLIT SHOWS

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PER CENT DIVORCED MALES DISAPPROVE OF HOMOSEXUALITY. THE CORRESPONDING FIGURE FOR MARRIED AND SINGLE MEN IS 80 PER CENT.